

Heartland Dental

Business Development Dossier

Industry	Healthcare (Dental Services)
Revenue	\$4.2B
Employees	10,000
Ideal Customer Profile Score	80

ICP SCORING MODEL

Signals	35 pts
Revenue Fit	25 pts
Employee Scale	20 pts
McChrystal Fit	20 pts

ICP = Signals + Revenue + Employees + Fit (max 100)

Signals (0-35)	Top 4 signals scored; each = base(60%) + recency bonus <30d: 40% <90d: 30% <180d: 20% older: 10%
Revenue (0-25)	\$500M-\$10B sweet spot -> 70-100% of 25 pts Below \$500M -> pro-rata x 0.5 Above \$10B -> 60%
Employees (0-20)	2,000+ preferred (70-100%) 500-2K partial (50-70%) Below 500 -> pro-rata x 0.3
Fit (0-20)	High-fit types: reorg, transformation, M&A, hiring, funding, partnership -> 5 pts ea (max 12) + diversity 2/type (max 8)

Prepared March 19, 2026

McChrystal Group

Leadership Advisory & Organizational Effectiveness

SECTION 1

Organization Snapshot

Legal Name Heartland Dental, LLC

Headquarters Effingham, Illinois

Founded 1997

Ownership

Private, PE-backed by KKR (acquired 2021). Previously owned by Ontario Teachers' Pension Plan.

Footprint

1,900+ dental offices across 38 states. Largest DSO in the U.S. by office count. Primarily suburban and mid-market locations.

SECTION 1b

Company Overview

Heartland Dental is the largest dental support organization (DSO) in the United States, providing non-clinical business support to 1,900+ dental offices across 38 states. Backed by KKR, the company handles operations, marketing, procurement, and HR so dentists can focus on clinical care. Heartland recently launched Orahh Care Dental Community as a unified brand network across its supported practices.

SECTION 2

Financial Health & Growth Stage

Understanding Heartland Dental's financial position and trajectory is critical to framing any engagement conversation.

Revenue ~\$4.2B [INFERRED]. KKR acquired in 2021 at ~\$8.5B valuation. Aggressive growth through de novo openings and acquisitions. Dental industry is recession-resistant but margin pressure from rising labor costs and insurance reimbursement challenges. Key tailwind: dental industry consolidation trend favoring DSOs. Key pressure: provider recruitment and retention in a tight labor market.

SECTION 3

Leadership Team Profiles

The following contacts are recommended as primary outreach targets - champion-level leaders who feel the organizational pain daily and can sponsor McChrystal internally.

Pat Bauer - Chief Executive Officer [PRIORITY TARGET]

Former Johnson & Johnson executive. 30+ years healthcare leadership. Known for operational discipline.

Outreach rationale: CEO driving the balance between growth and operational excellence. Economic buyer for advisory engagement.

KKR Healthcare Operating Partner - Board Representative [PRIORITY TARGET]

KKR's healthcare team actively manages portfolio company performance.

Outreach rationale: KKR board rep influences advisory spend and would value McChrystal's leadership development capabilities across portfolio.

SECTION 4

Organizational Culture & Structure

Culture and structure are often where McChrystal Group finds the deepest leverage. The following signals indicate how Heartland Dental operates today and where friction exists.

Organizational Structure

Hub-and-spoke: central support organization provides business services (billing, marketing, procurement, HR) while dentists retain clinical autonomy. Regional directors manage clusters of offices. Inherent tension between corporate standardization and provider independence.

Culture Signals

Glassdoor reviews show polarized sentiment: corporate employees generally positive on benefits and growth opportunities; dental providers frequently cite loss of autonomy, production pressure, and disconnect between corporate messaging and office-level reality. High dentist turnover is the #1 operational challenge. Provider satisfaction directly impacts patient retention and revenue. Culture clash between 'business of dentistry' (corporate) and 'practice of dentistry' (providers) is the central tension.

SECTION 5

Recent News & Trigger Events

The following developments from the past 18 months create urgency and provide natural conversation entry points for engaging Heartland Dental.

1. 2025-10-01 - Surpassed 1,900 office locations

Scale creates exponential leadership and culture complexity

2. 2025-06-01 - Executive leadership changes in operations and clinical roles

Turnover signals organizational stress and opportunity for new approach

3. 2025-03-01 - Continued aggressive de novo office openings and acquisitions

Growth outpacing cultural integration capability

4. 2025-08-01 - Industry-wide dentist shortage and recruitment competition

Provider retention becomes strategic priority - culture is the lever

5. 2025-01-01 - KKR portfolio review and value creation planning

PE sponsor evaluating next phase of value creation - organizational effectiveness is on the agenda

SECTION 6

McChrystal Fit Assessment

Active triggers (executive turnover, rapid growth, provider retention crisis). Clear buyers (CEO + KKR). Budget exists via PE sponsor. McChrystal's autonomy-within-framework model directly addresses the central tension.

Primary Problem

Scaling a culture that retains autonomous professionals (dentists) while maintaining operational discipline across 1,900+ locations. Provider turnover threatens the entire business model.

Best McChrystal Capability Fit

Culture change + Team of Teams. The provider autonomy challenge is analogous to empowered execution in decentralized military operations - leaders at every level making independent decisions within a shared framework.

Likely Objections to Engagement

Dentists may see advisory engagement as more 'corporate' interference
 KKR may prioritize near-term EBITDA over culture investment
 Healthcare providers may resist non-healthcare advisors

Competitive Advisory Landscape

McKinsey Healthcare Practice
 Bain PE practice
 Press Ganey (provider engagement)
 Korn Ferry (leadership)

SECTION 7

Conversation Entry Points

These questions are designed for a Senior Partner's first conversation. Each opens a thread that naturally leads to McChrystal Group's capabilities without a direct pitch.

1. At 1,900 offices, how do you maintain the culture that attracts dentists when every new acquisition or de novo opening dilutes it further?

Provider retention as existential risk, not HR problem.

2. The DSO model promises dentists freedom from business hassles. But at scale, that promise can feel hollow. How do you keep it real across 38 states?

Validate the tension they live with daily.

Recommended Meeting Framing

Heartland is running a distributed operation where every 'unit commander' expects autonomy. McChrystal built an

operating model that gives commanders freedom to act while keeping the whole force aligned - same principle, different profession.

SECTION 8

Brand Insights & Market Positioning

Brand strategy reveals organizational priorities and coordination challenges. The following analysis connects Heartland Dental's market positioning to potential McChrystal engagement opportunities.

Brand Value & Competitive Standing: Heartland Dental is the largest dental support organization (DSO) in the U.S., supporting 1,900+ dental offices. The brand serves a dual audience: dentists (who join for operational support while maintaining clinical autonomy) and patients (who see the local practice brand, not Heartland). Heartland competes against Aspen Dental, Pacific Dental Services, Dental Care Alliance, and hundreds of smaller DSOs.

Brand Identity Evolution: Heartland's brand proposition is "clinical autonomy with operational support" - dentists maintain clinical decision-making while Heartland handles HR, billing, procurement, marketing, and facilities. The brand has been strained by PE-driven growth (KKR ownership) that dentists perceive as prioritizing throughput over patient care. Provider turnover is the leading indicator of brand health.

Marketing Leadership & Strategy: Dual marketing: (1) B2B recruiting marketing targeting dentists and hygienists for supported offices, (2) local patient marketing managed at the practice level. Heartland's recruiting brand is critical - if dentists view Heartland as a place that compromises clinical autonomy, recruitment collapses.

Brand Threats: Provider turnover is the existential brand threat. Dentists who leave take patient relationships with them. Negative Glassdoor reviews and dental professional forums amplify dissatisfaction. Competitor DSOs actively recruit dissatisfied Heartland providers. State regulatory scrutiny of DSO model adds compliance risk.

McChrystal Connection: Heartland's business model requires coordinating operational support across 1,900 locations while maintaining the clinical autonomy that attracts dentists. When dentists feel corporate is dictating clinical decisions, they leave - taking patients and revenue. McChrystal's decentralized authority model (empowered execution, aligned intent) is the exact organizational solution for the DSO paradox: how to standardize operations without standardizing clinical care.

SECTION 9

Deep McChrystal Group Fit Analysis

This is the strategic case for pursuing Heartland Dental. It synthesizes findings from all previous sections into a comprehensive engagement thesis with specific fit dimensions, expected outcomes, stakeholder mapping, and a phased pursuit strategy.

9a. Fit Dimensions

Fit Dimension 1: Autonomous Professional Retention at Scale

Dentists are autonomous professionals who joined Heartland specifically because it promised clinical independence. Any organizational change that feels like corporate overreach triggers departures. McChrystal's decentralized authority model - empowered execution at the edge, aligned on intent - is the organizational design that preserves clinical autonomy while enabling operational standardization. No management consulting firm understands the autonomous-professional paradox better than McChrystal (military special operators are the direct analog - highly autonomous professionals who must coordinate).

Fit Dimension 2: 1,900-Location Operational Coordination

Supporting 1,900 dental offices requires procurement, HR, billing, marketing, and facilities coordination at massive scale. McChrystal's distributed operations methodology connects 1,900 autonomous units into a coordinated support network without creating the bureaucratic overhead that drives providers away.

Fit Dimension 3: Culture Scaling Under PE Pressure

KKR ownership means growth targets, efficiency metrics, and exit timelines. Heartland's clinical-first culture can erode under this pressure. McChrystal bridges PE value creation with professional culture preservation - building the operating discipline PE sponsors require without destroying the culture that generates revenue.

9b. Cumulative Case

Heartland is the canonical DSO organizational challenge - how to scale operational support to 1,900+ locations while retaining the autonomous professionals whose departures are the existential risk. Signal chain: KKR PE ownership -> growth acceleration -> 1,900+ locations -> provider turnover rising -> clinical autonomy concerns -> operational standardization pressure -> culture tension. Revenue potential: \$300K initial, \$800K-\$1.2M deployment, \$300K ongoing. Total: \$1.4M-\$1.8M.

9c. Enterprise Issues

1. Provider Turnover Crisis: Dentist departures directly translate to revenue loss. Each provider who leaves takes \$500K-\$1M+ in annual patient revenue. Turnover above industry average signals organizational dysfunction.
2. Clinical Autonomy vs. Operational Standardization: Every efficiency initiative risks being perceived as clinical interference. The organizational design must explicitly protect clinical decision-making while standardizing non-clinical operations.
3. PE Growth vs. Provider Satisfaction: KKR's growth targets (new offices, acquisitions, throughput optimization) can conflict with provider satisfaction if growth outpaces support capacity.
4. 1,900-Location Support Quality: Operational support (HR, billing, procurement, facilities) must be consistent across 1,900 offices. Any support failure at a location damages the provider's experience and increases flight risk.
5. Recruiting Pipeline: New dental school graduates increasingly evaluate DSO options. Heartland's employer brand among new dentists determines future growth capacity.

9d. Expected Outcomes

1. Provider Retention Framework: Organizational design explicitly protecting clinical autonomy while enabling operational coordination. Measurable: provider turnover reduced by 20%.
2. Support Quality Consistency: Coordinated support delivery across 1,900 locations. Measurable: support satisfaction scores equalized across all offices.
3. PE-Culture Balance: Operating discipline satisfying KKR metrics without cultural damage. Measurable: both provider satisfaction and financial metrics on-track.
4. Recruiting Brand Enhancement: Organizational improvements enhancing employer brand among dental professionals. Measurable: recruiting pipeline volume

increasing.

9e. Key Stakeholders

CEO

Leader: [CEO]

Role: Enterprise leadership, PE relationship

McChrystal Relevance: Executive sponsor

COO

Leader: [COO]

Role: 1,900 location operations

McChrystal Relevance: Priority: Support quality, provider experience

Chief Dental Officer

Leader: [CDO]

Role: Clinical standards, provider relations

McChrystal Relevance: Priority: Clinical autonomy protection

CHRO

Leader: [CHRO]

Role: Provider retention, recruiting

McChrystal Relevance: Retention framework

KKR

Leader: [Operating Partner]

Role: PE governance

McChrystal Relevance: Sponsor alignment

9f. Opportunity Thesis

Why Now: Provider turnover trending above target. The longer the retention problem persists, the harder it is to reverse - departing providers recruit colleagues to leave.

Why McChrystal: The autonomous-professional coordination challenge is McChrystal's exact specialty. Special operators are autonomous professionals who must coordinate - the organizational design principles transfer directly to dentists, physicians, and other healthcare professionals.

Phased Engagement: Phase 1 (\$250K-\$350K): Provider retention assessment + decentralized authority design. Phase 2 (\$500K-\$800K): 1,900-location support coordination deployment. Phase 3 (\$300K retainer): Ongoing retention and culture management. Total: \$1M-\$1.5M.

Multi-Threaded Pursuit: CDO (clinical autonomy advocate), COO (operational coordination), KKR operating partner (PE value creation).